

The anonymous Internet

Daily Tor users per 100,000 Internet users

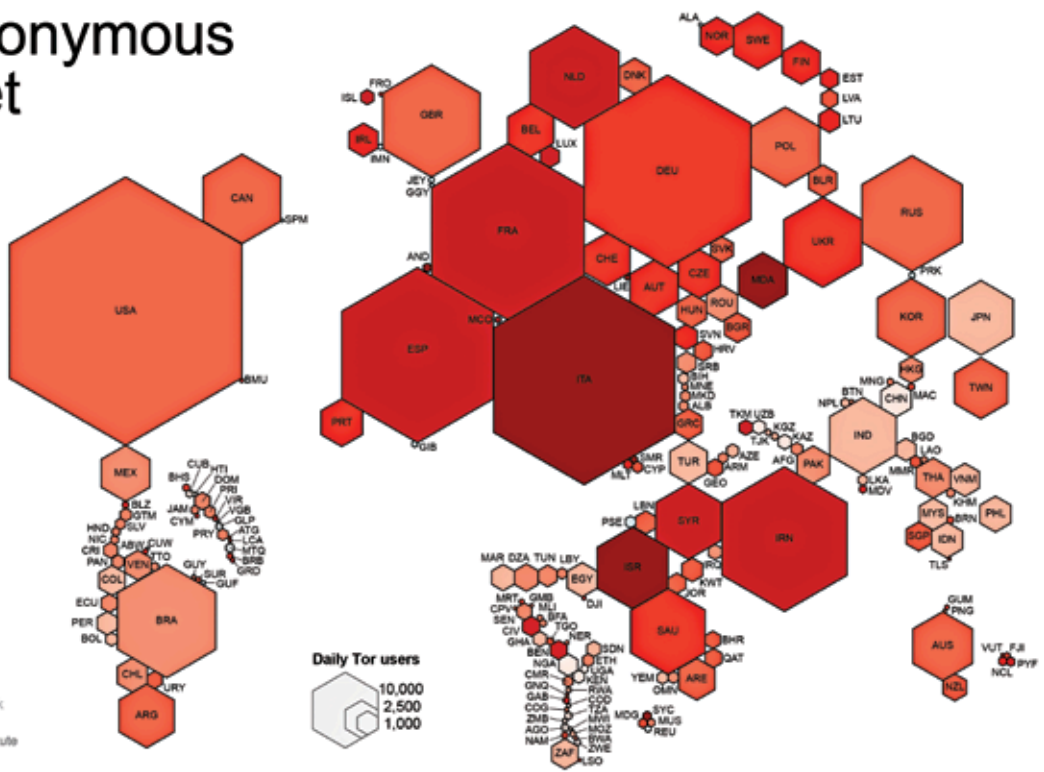
- > 200
- 100 - 200
- 50 - 100
- 25 - 50
- 10 - 25
- 5 - 10
- < 5
- no information

Average number of Tor users per day calculated between August 2012 and July 2013

data sources:
Tor Metrics Portal
metrics.torproject.org
World Bank
data.worldbank.org

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University of Oxford



Infographic depicting global usage pattern of Tor

you visit, shutting down tracking cookies etc. The visual representation makes the actual workings of a VPN easier to understand. It does offer a limited set of options when it comes to servers, with the free versions mainly having European servers. Also, there is a three hour restriction on sessions.

Another alternative is Tunnelbear, with user friendly apps available for almost all platforms and one of the widest network of servers to choose from (only the India and Australia options are restricted in the free version). The catch here is the 500MB data restriction per month, which is pretty useless if you are using it to watch location-restricted videos online.

You also have a couple of options if you are looking to hide your phone, consoles and other connected devices as well. One such option is VPNBook, which doesn't require any specific software and works once you enter specific information into your machine's system settings. Keep in mind that this one is the most open of all the options suggested so far.

You can also access content that's normally blocked in your geographical

location thanks to a VPN. A VPN also helps when, say, you find that a lot of people are sharing a YouTube video on social networks that just doesn't play for you. Using a VPN you could just choose a server in the US, or some place where the video isn't blocked, and watch what all the fuss is about. Of course, the biggest disadvantage of VPNs is the fact that you're adding a whole new route to all your internet traffic, and that is obviously going to add on a lot of response time to all of your traffic. This can be frustrating to some.

Tor

The Tor browser allows you to access the internet with total anonymity. It is very popular in countries such as Iran and China, where government censorship is pretty oppressive. It's not at all recommended for regular browsing though, and certainly not for accessing sites you would normally enter passwords into, but for regular browsing, it can work when all else fails. The Tor network works by constantly changing the IPs you are connected to, which makes anyone trying to trace something back to you an almost impossible task.

The developers of Tor have been up in arms against censorship of the internet, and keep updating their software that works even in cases where VPNs, proxies and SSH tunnels are known to fail. Browsing on Tor can be super slow and painful though, because of all the randomising of IPs and all that.

BETTER BE A JACK OF ALL

While it may seem that any one of these methods of getting access to your torrents and other P2P sites would work, it's important that you learn all of them, because when it comes to digital security, privacy and freedom, each of these is a pretty good choice. Always remember, however, that each movie, game or song that you download without paying reduces the income of the artist – which may be fine for the multimillionaires who pretend to be pop-stars, but real musicians and artists can really suffer. While it's important for us to inform you how to bypass silly restrictions on the internet, we still urge you to carefully consider staying on the right side of the law. 